Cover Letter — Senior Product Engineer (Sydney, growth-stage fintech)

Dear SustainRecruit Team,

I'm applying for the Senior Product Engineer role. You're hiring a builder — someone who owns outcomes, writes the spec and the code, and directs AI to ship. That has been my actual job for the past several years, and the shape of my whole career.

Over nine years at Cubewise I progressed from client-facing web developer to Lead AI Architect and Product Owner for the Apliqo UX platform, an enterprise FP&A SaaS product. There was no handoff between product and engineering: I owned the roadmap and made the scoping and sequencing calls, and stayed hands-on with the code — full-stack development, API design and performance engineering at big-data scale. In September 2025 I shipped AVA, the platform's AI assistant, from vision and architecture through to production rollout, with deployments at Amazon, AWS and ZKB.

Three things I'd bring:

- **Product instinct with engineering depth.** I ask "should we build this?" before "how do we build this?" — my roadmap rule was that every initiative had to be technically sound, user-centric and aligned with business strategy. When the answer was yes, I built it myself: production-grade, full-stack, built to last.
  - **AI-native by practice, not slogan.** I evaluated and selected the models, set the AI implementation standards, and mentored 10+ developers on AI patterns. I've worked in AI-directed, agent-first workflows since before they had a name — and I know where judgement still beats implementation.
  - **A decade of talking to users.** Client-facing consulting across enterprises including Westpac, Optus and Goodman, plus training 30+ consultants. I can explain a technical trade-off to a founder as easily as a product decision to an engineer.

A small team at a growth-stage fintech with fuzzy requirements suits me: I've spent my career building software for finance teams — budgeting, forecasting, planning — so I speak your users' language, and ambiguity is where I do my best work.

My resume is attached, and my live work is at tokenizmyapp.vercel.app, prestix.vip and gofetchapp.vercel.app — more in the resume. I'd welcome a conversation.

Kind regards,

Ilia Shapiro
Mob: 0414 557 038 | reward2learn@gmail.com | linkedin.com/in/iliashapiro